

What it takes to win a grand final

We compared United with Echuca, who won the 2026 flag 141 to 60 over Shepparton Bears, and with all 12 clubs. United already use the ball as well as any team in the league. The gap is in winning it: contested ball, pressure and getting it inside 50.

+24.0

contested possessions
a game Echuca had
over United

+10.8

tackles a game Echuca
laid over United

+7.3

inside 50s a game
Echuca had over United

+3.2

goals a game Echuca
kicked over United

The short version. Keep the kicking and marking game. Add a contested, high-pressure edge in the midfield. United are 1st in the league for marks and kicking efficiency, but those stats had almost no link to ladder position this year. Contested ball, tackling, intercepts and inside 50s did.

The five priorities

In order of how far United are behind the premiers. Each bar is a per-game average for 2026. The black tick is the league average.

■ Shepparton United ■ Echuca (premiers) | League average

1 Win the contested ball

This is the biggest gap between United and the premiers. Echuca were 1st in the league in all three. United were 8th, 11th and 12th. Across the league, contested possessions tracked ladder position closely (link 0.82; 1.00 would be perfect).



Premiership standard: **148.2 contested possessions** a game (average of Echuca and Shepparton Bears). United: 128.9. That is **19.3 more a game**, about **5 more per quarter**.

2 Bring the pressure: tackles and pressure acts

United applied the least pressure in the competition (12th) and were 10th for tackles. Echuca laid 10.8 more tackles a game, 8.6 of them in the midfield. In United's two games against Echuca they were out-tackled 77 to 60 and 64 to 58.



Premiership standard: **66.5 tackles** a game (average of Echuca and Shepparton Bears). United: 55.2. That is **11.2 more a game**, about **2.8 more per quarter**.

3 Get the ball inside 50 more often

Inside 50s were the stat most linked to United's winning margin this year. United averaged 54.2 in wins and 42.4 in losses. Echuca averaged 55.6, the most in the league. United already take plenty of marks inside 50 (2nd), so more entries should turn into more scores.



Premiership standard: **55.2 inside 50s** a game (average of Echuca and Shepparton Bears). United: 48.3. That is **6.9 more a game**, about **1.7 more per quarter**.

4 Kick straighter when it counts

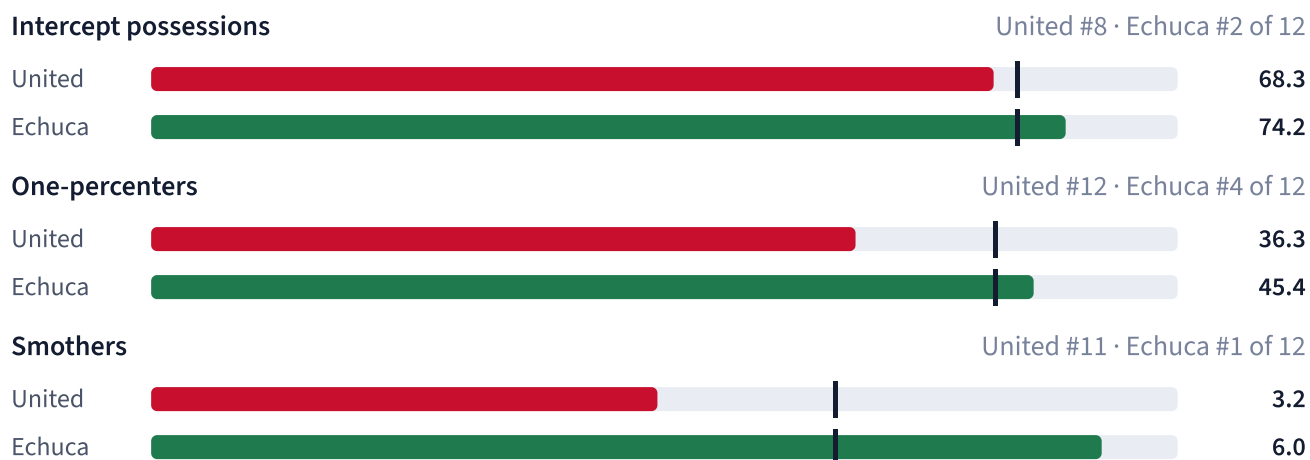
United kicked 11.6 goals a game at 50% accuracy. Echuca kicked 14.8 at 53%, and lifted to 58–69% in their three finals (16–21 goals a game). Across the league, goal accuracy tracked ladder position closely (link 0.85).



Premiership standard: **14.2 goals** a game (average of Echuca and Shepparton Bears). United: 11.6. That is **2.6 more a game**, about **0.6 more per quarter**.

5 Win it back: intercepts, spoils and smothers

Intercept possessions had the strongest link to ladder position of any possession stat (link 0.90). United were 8th. They were last for one-percenters and 11th for smothers, so the defensive effort acts that stop opposition scores are also missing.



Premiership standard: **75.7 intercept possessions** a game (average of Echuca and Shepparton Bears).
United: 68.3. That is **7.4 more a game**, about **1.8 more per quarter**.

What separates the top teams

How closely each stat moved with ladder percentage across all 12 clubs. 1.00 means the better the stat, the higher the club finished, every time.

STAT (PER GAME)	LINK TO LADDER	UNITED RANK
Intercept possessions	0.90	#8
Inside 50s	0.89	#7
Goal accuracy %	0.85	#4
Contested possessions	0.82	#8
Forward-50 tackles	0.78	#9
Clearances	0.77	#8
Marks	0.21	#1
Uncontested marks	0.12	#1
Disposal efficiency %	0.11	#1

The top six stats are all about winning the ball and getting it forward. United's best stats, marks and disposal efficiency, sit at the bottom. They are worth keeping, but on their own they don't win you a flag.

Keep doing this

United's strengths. These are a real edge and shouldn't be traded away.

STAT (PER GAME)	UNITED	RANK	ECHUCA	RANK
Marks	110.4	#1	99.3	#4
Uncontested marks	96.1	#1	84.0	#4
Kick efficiency %	64.0	#1	62.0	#2
Disposal efficiency %	69.0	#1	69.0	#1
Midfield turnovers (fewer is better)	39.0	#1	43.2	#6

Head to head with Echuca

Round 6: United 60, Echuca 97; Round 17: United 71, Echuca 171.

STAT	R6 UNITED	ECHUCA	DIFF	R17 UNITED	ECHUCA	DIFF
Contested possessions	133	130	+3	109	145	-36
Clearances	40	49	-9	37	59	-22
Inside 50s	42	42	+0	38	62	-24
Tackles	60	77	-17	58	64	-6
Overall pressure	88	118	-30	114	122	-8
Scoring shots	20	22	-2	21	36	-15
Goals	8	15	-7	10	27	-17

In Round 6 United matched Echuca for possession and inside 50s but lost the tackle count by 17 and the pressure count by 30. In Round 17 Echuca won every area. That was the 100-point loss.

How Echuca played their finals

Echuca's three finals compared with United's season averages.

GAME	CONTESTED POSS.	CLEARANCES	INSIDE 50S	TACKLES	GOALS	GOAL ACCURACY
FW1 v Shepparton Bears	179	45	57	93	16	69
FW2 v Kyabram	146	35	56	57	19	59
GF v Shepparton Bears	143	49	53	53	21	58
United season average	128.9	41.8	48.3	55.2	11.6	48

Finals footy was more contested again. Echuca averaged 156.0 contested possessions and 55.3 inside 50s, and kicked 18.7 goals a game. A team built on uncontested marking will need a stronger contested game to match that in September.

Targets for 2027

MEASURE (PER GAME)	UNITED 2026	PREMIERSHIP STANDARD	CHANGE NEEDED
Contested possessions	128.9	148.2	+19.3
Groundball gets	77.9	95.4	+17.5
Tackles	55.2	66.5	+11.2
Overall pressure	105.2	131.3	+26.1
Inside 50s	48.3	55.2	+6.9
Intercept possessions	68.3	75.7	+7.4
Goals	11.6	14.2	+2.6
Goal accuracy %	50.0	52.5	+2.5
Marks	110.4	97.2	Hold (already above)
Kick efficiency %	64.0	61.0	Hold (already above)

"Premiership standard" is the average of the two best teams in 2026: Echuca (premiers) and Shepparton Bears (minor premiers, runners-up).

Source: Premier Data (Shepparton United club account), 2026 Goulburn Valley League season, all rounds including finals. Per-game averages from the Leaderboards. Echuca's include their 3 finals; United played 18 games. "Link" is a correlation across the 12 clubs, a guide rather than proof. Full numbers are in the spreadsheet *Shepparton_United_vs_Echuca_2026.xlsx*.